M-ZRT (ELI5)

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Short Research Note

Internal **evaluation** can be defined as the rapid emergence of thoughts such as: "Am I doing this right?" and "What's the point?".

Move your shoulders for a few seconds, then observe what happens. Very quickly, an evaluation appears: "Am I doing this right?" "What's the point?" It often arises even before the action itself, in the form of anticipation.

Now repeat exactly the same movement, but while facing a first-person shooter (FPS) video game. This time, evaluation does not activate **immediately**. It seems delayed by a few seconds, often around 4 to 5 seconds.

Without a game:
Anticipation ~5 seconds
Shoulder movement ~3 seconds
+1 second: emergence of meaning-search and evaluation ("Am I doing this right?", "What's the point?")

This process is automatic. It reflects a monitoring system that activates in a nearly inevitable way. Trying to block it voluntarily tends to **reinforce** it, because the attempt itself becomes an object of evaluation.

With an FPS or fast-paced game:
Anticipation ~2 seconds
Shoulder movement ~3 seconds
+5 seconds: emergence of meaning-search and evaluation

What we observe here is a temporal shift. Evaluation is not removed, but **delayed**. This delay creates a window during which the action can exist without being immediately captured by the monitoring system.

This therefore becomes a first useful exercise to make visible the mechanism we are trying to bypass. Compare with and without the game, and consider this contrast as a first “attack” on the internal monitoring system, as if it were momentarily **stunned**.

This result shows that there is a temporal window during which evaluation is delayed. During this interval, the action is not immediately captured by processes of meaning, optimization, and judgment.

In other words, it becomes possible to introduce micro-events that are not immediately evaluated. These are not “messages” in an explicit sense, but rather action configurations that temporarily escape the filtering of the monitoring system.

The goal is to push it back enough to create a stable window. When this shift is strong enough, one can observe the reappearance of more intense dopaminergic responses.

The monitoring system does not only evaluate actions. It also monitors **attempts** to bypass it. It therefore includes the “setups” themselves, such as choosing a game.

This is why the first hours of a game are often experienced as “magical,” and then the effect fades. The system learns the context, anticipates what will happen, and reintegrates the experience into an evaluative loop.

This leads to an important constraint:
Yes, it is possible to introduce micro-events that temporarily escape evaluation, but these events must remain very **brief** and **non-repetitive.**

As soon as there is anticipation, comparison, or an attempt at reproduction, the monitoring system reactivates and captures the event. Forcing or repeating only reinforces this capture.

After a too explicit or repeated attempt, the system remains active and vigilant for some time, making subsequent attempts much less effective.

From a practical standpoint:
the duration must remain very short (up to ~1 minute at most)

the event should not be repeated multiple times within the same day

it should be left without analysis or attempts at reproduction

it should be treated as a one-off event, then abandoned

In other words, this is not a cumulative or optimizable practice. It operates as a **switch-like** logic, non-repeated, and should not become something to improve.

A simple example of how the monitoring system works:

Suppose I give you a task to perform. The first time, you discover it. Anticipation is relatively low, because the action is not yet well known.

But afterward, you know what to expect. Anticipation increases. The monitor recognizes the situation, reactivates, and captures the action. At that point, the task loses its effect, because it is immediately evaluated.

If you wait longer, for example a day, part of that familiarity fades. The memory is less precise, anticipation decreases. The context becomes partially “open” again.

Under these conditions, the monitor is less active, or slower to trigger. The task can pass again.

What kind of signals?

We can introduce a more technical idea here: prediction error.

A fast-paced game, such as an FPS, constantly generates micro-violations of prediction, which temporarily disrupts the operation of the monitoring system.

If, within this window, you perform a simple gesture, only once, without trying to evaluate it, that gesture becomes a particular kind of signal, indicating: optimization does not apply here.

We can then distinguish two types of signals entering at the same time:

prediction errors (coming from the game, from the unpredictable flow)

a local suspension of optimization (the gesture performed without evaluation)

It is their combination that destabilizes the monitoring system.

Paradoxically, the monitor does not oppose the task directly, it even tries to improve it. It evaluates, corrects, adjusts, in close interaction with the optimization system. The two operate almost as a single unit.

This is why thoughts such as:
“What is the best exercise?”
“How can I do it better?”

appear almost automatically.

But these thoughts are already forms of evaluation. So they reactivate precisely the system we were trying to disengage.

The key point is the following:
the monitor can cooperate with the attempt, in order to better turn it into an object of optimization.

And once the task becomes an object of optimization, it is neutralized.

We can therefore consider that:
The monitor and the optimization system are not separate. They form a single functional unit.

This unit has a very specific property:
it eliminates anything that cannot be used.

As a result, any non-instrumental intensity is usually reduced or suppressed.

The task:

Download Unreal Tournament (1999), remove the HUD, and start a match with no performance goal. Do not try to win.

While playing:
make a brief shoulder movement, only once, without prolonging it

then, let your attention float lightly over the game, without fully engaging

take a very small sip of coffee

Then:
close the game

do not analyze anything

completely forget the exercise

The next day, you can perform another instance, but slightly change the order (for example, coffee before the game). The idea is to prevent the sequence from becoming recognizable.

The coffee is there to slightly increase overall activation. The dose should remain low, to avoid making the state too “suspicious” for the monitoring system.

Important point, to make very clear:

This is not a routine to optimize.

If you start asking yourself:
"What is the best order?"

"What is the best dose?"

"How can I improve the effect?"

then you have already reactivated the monitor.